Generated from `docs/handoff-guides/markdown/design/concepts.md` by `tools/guide-publisher`.

Concepts Handoff Guide

Use this guide when you need to describe **business concepts, important terms, identities, classifications, states, and relationships**.

This guide is about **what things mean** in the domain before you talk about processes, screens, or implementation.

KNOWLEDGE AREA

This guide helps with **business terms and meanings**. Technically, it covers **domain semantics and business ontology**.

Guide family map

Where this guide sits in the full Blueprint Handoff Atlas family.

ROOT & CROSS-CUTTING

Handoff Atlas | Blueprint Bundle | Metamodel Vocabulary | Migrations

DESIGN

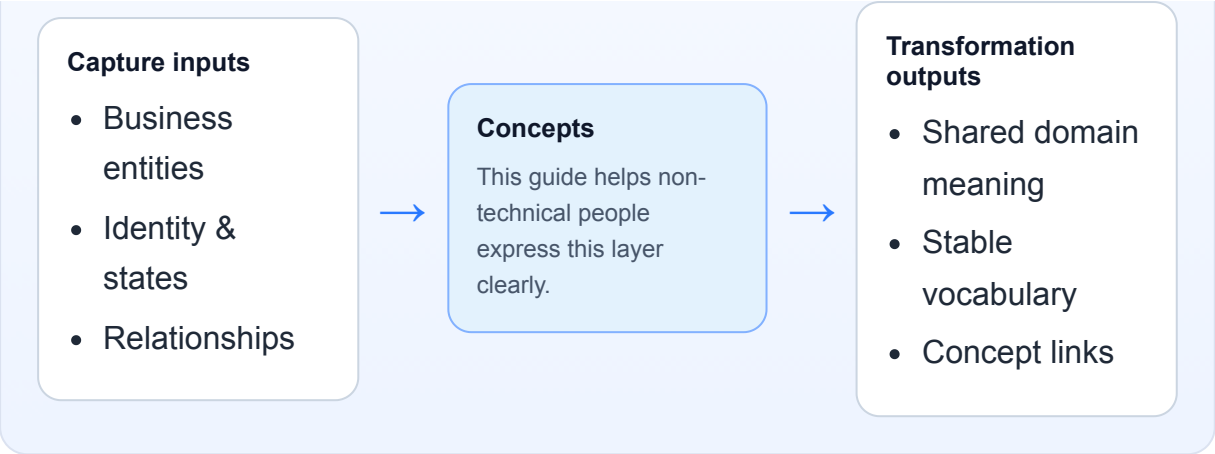
Architecture | **Concepts** | Domain | Dynamics | Infrastructure | Interactions | Models | Quality | Rules | Story

GOVERNANCE

Capability | Decisions | Motivation | Organization | Roadmap | Leverage | Test Cases | Value Stream

Capture → focus → transformation

What to gather first, what this layer focuses on, and what a modeler or AI agent can produce from it.



Main entities in this guide

- **Concept** - a business thing or idea the model must name clearly and keep stable.
- **Actor** - a person, role, or external participant that does something in the domain.
- **Enumeration** - a closed list of allowed values or states.
- **Association** - a meaningful relationship between concepts.
  - Often confused with: **Entity** in the Architecture guide. Use **Concept** here when the meaning matters; use **Entity** there when the structural picture matters.

What belongs here

Capture things like:

- important business entities
- people, roles, or external actors
- classifications or statuses
- identifiers
- lifecycle states
- relationships between concepts

What does not belong here

- a full process flow - capture that in the Story guide
- screen behavior - capture that in the Interactions guide
- detailed technical storage structures unless they matter to business meaning

Core things to capture

Describe:

- the **concept name**
- what it **means**
- how you **recognize** one
- what makes it **different** from similar concepts
- what key properties matter in business terms
- whether it has states, classifications, or examples

Core relationships to capture

Make these links explicit in your text:

- concept -> related concept
- owner/container -> contained thing
- concept -> actor that uses it
- concept -> story where it appears
- concept -> status/classification/state

Modus operandi

When eliciting concepts, work from language and meaning:

1. list the important nouns and named things in the domain
2. merge duplicates and separate look-alikes
3. define each concept in plain language
4. identify how one instance is recognized
5. capture important relationships
6. add states, examples, and distinctions only where they add clarity

Focus on business meaning, not on database or UI representation.

Prompt set

Use questions like these:

- what is this thing?
- how do we know one instance from another?
- what information about it matters to the business?
- what states can it be in?
- what other concepts does it relate to?
- what is often confused with it?

- where does it appear in the main stories or screens?

Free-text intake template

Use this template when gathering notes:

- **Concept name:**
- **Meaning:**
- **How to recognize one:**
- **Key business properties:**
- **Possible states or classifications:**
- **Related concepts:**
- **Examples:**
- **Where it appears in stories or interactions:**
- **What it is often confused with:**

Worked example

Example: return request

- **Concept name:** Return Request
- **Meaning:** a request by a customer to send purchased items back for refund or exchange
- **How to recognize one:** it belongs to one order and one selected set of order items
- **Key business properties:** customer, order number, items, return reason, refund method, decision
- **Possible states:** draft, submitted, approved, rejected, completed
- **Related concepts:** customer, order, refund, return shipment
- **Examples:** damaged-item return, wrong-size exchange request
- **Appears in:** return request submission story, return request form, support review screen
- **Often confused with:** refund transaction, return shipment

Layer-specific handoff guidance

For concepts, the handoff must preserve **meaning and distinction**.

A good concept handoff should let the receiver answer:

- what this concept means
- how one instance is recognized

- how it differs from nearby concepts
- where it appears in stories, rules, or interactions

If a concept could still be confused with another named thing, tighten the definition before handoff.

How this becomes YAML

A technical modeler or AI agent can transform this into a concepts layer by:

- turning the named business concepts into concepts or actors
- recording identity, states, and examples where useful
- mapping relationships between concepts
- linking concepts to stories, rules, and interactions elsewhere in the Blueprint

You do not need to decide formal IDs or low-level structure.

Common mistakes

- naming a concept without defining what it means
- describing technical storage instead of business meaning
- missing identity or distinguishing characteristics
- forgetting relationships between concepts
- duplicating the same concept under slightly different names
- mixing concept definition with full process description